GUIDE 04

The 3AM Signal

Why you wake up in the dark, wide awake, and what to do about it tonight.

The Kira Method

6 things your body does at night · 4 things besides stress that can wake you up · A 12-minute wind-down to try tonight

READ THIS FIRST

Waking at 3AM is common. It is also a clue.

Most people wake up a few times a night. Most of the time they roll over and never remember it. When you are *wide awake* at 3AM, staring at the ceiling, something pushed you past the normal wake-up. This guide helps you find what.

1. **6 things your body does at night**, so 3AM makes sense (Chapter 1).
2. **4 things besides stress** that can wake you up (Chapter 2).
3. **A 12-minute wind-down** to try tonight, plus what to do when you are awake at 3AM (Chapter 3).

Please read: this is education, not medical advice

We are not doctors. Poor sleep has many causes, and some need medical care. We label how strong the evidence is for each idea. Do not start sleeping pills or supplements without talking to your doctor.

The number to remember

Adults should get **at least 7 hours** of sleep a night, say the American Academy of Sleep Medicine and the Sleep Research Society. A CDC figure reported in the news says about 3 in 10 U.S. adults got less than that in 2024. You are not alone.

CHAPTER 1

6 things your body does at night

Knowing the normal pattern takes a lot of fear out of 3AM.

1 It cools down

Your core body temperature falls as you drift off. Sleep tends to begin on the downward slope of that curve. A cool bedroom helps. A very warm bed can get in the way.

2 It turns on melatonin

Melatonin is a hormone your brain releases as it gets dark. It helps tell your body "it is night." It rises as your temperature drops. Melatonin is a timing signal, not a sedative.

3 It runs in loops of about 90 minutes

You move from light sleep to deep sleep to dream sleep (REM), then start over. Each loop takes roughly 90 to 110 minutes, and you get about four to six a night. Sleep is lightest at the end of each loop.

4 It gives you deep sleep early and lighter sleep late

Deep sleep is more common early in the night. Later loops are lighter. Around 3AM it takes less to wake you: a noise, a hot flash, a full bladder.

5 It wakes you up briefly, many times

Short wake-ups at the end of a sleep loop are normal. Most people fall back asleep fast and forget them. The trouble starts when the mind latches on ("Why am I awake? I have work at 8").

6 It starts raising cortisol toward morning

Cortisol helps you feel alert. It follows a daily rhythm and starts rising in the early morning hours. You will read that "cortisol wakes you at 3AM." That is only partly right. The rise is normal. It does not mean something is broken.

> **What this adds up to**
>
> Late-night sleep is lighter and cortisol is rising, so it is the easiest time for something to push you fully awake. Ask: **"What woke me, and why can't I drop back off?"**

CHAPTER 2

4 things besides stress that can wake you up

Stress is real. But it is the answer people jump to. These four are often missed.

1 Sleep apnea (breathing pauses) COMMON, OFTEN MISSED IN WOMEN

In sleep apnea, breathing briefly stops or gets shallow many times a night. Each time, your brain wakes you just enough to restart breathing. You may not remember it.

In women, it often does not look like the classic loud snoring. Doctors report that women more often describe **tiredness, insomnia, morning headaches and low mood**. The risk goes up during and after menopause, and it is often underdiagnosed in women. Women are less likely to have a partner who notices pauses.

Ask your doctor about a sleep test if you…

- ☐ snore, gasp, or choke at night (or someone has told you),
- ☐ wake with a headache or a dry mouth,
- ☐ are tired all day even after a full night in bed,
- ☐ wake often and need to pee (see #4).

2 Hormone changes and night sweats COMMON IN THE 40S AND 50S

As estrogen changes, the body’s temperature control gets less steady. A flush of heat and sweat can pull you out of sleep. If you wake hot and damp, say so to your doctor. Treatment options exist.

Worth knowing

A Harvard Health report on a menopause sleep study said some night waking women blame on hot flashes may actually be caused by sleep disorders such as sleep apnea. So if “it must be menopause” is your answer, it is still worth checking for apnea.

3 A glass of wine (the “nightcap”) STRONG EVIDENCE

Alcohol can help you fall asleep faster and deepen sleep in the **first half** of the night. But a peer-reviewed review found that sleep is disrupted in the **second half**. Moderate amounts of alcohol disturb dream sleep mostly late in the night. That fits a 3AM wake-up exactly.

Try: Do not drink for 3 to 4 hours before bed for 2 weeks. Compare your nights. (If you drink a lot daily, do not stop suddenly on your own. Talk to your doctor.)

4 A full bladder OFTEN LINKED TO OTHER CAUSES

Waking up to pee at night (nocturia) is common. Lower estrogen can change how your body holds water at night, and weaker pelvic floor muscles can add to it. Sleep apnea is also linked to nighttime urination in women. And sometimes the urge to pee did not wake you: you woke for another reason, then noticed your bladder.

Try: Drink most of your fluids earlier in the day. Ask your doctor if you wake to pee twice or more a night.

> **Also on the list (smaller, easy to check)**
>
> Room too warm, light from outside, noise, a late heavy meal, or a pet. Fix those first. They cost nothing.

CHAPTER 3

A 12-minute wind-down to try tonight

This is a routine built from habits that sleep experts and studies back, put into a short, doable block. It is not a cure, and a routine alone will not fix sleep apnea or night sweats. Try it for 14 nights and see.

Minutes 1–4
Empty your head

Write tomorrow's to-do list. Then add one line: "If I wake up, I do not have to solve this now."

Evidence: in a small 2018 study (57 healthy young adults), people who wrote a to-do list for 5 minutes fell asleep in about 16 minutes. Those who wrote about what they had already done took about 25. Small and young, so treat it as promising.

Minutes 5–9
Slow your body

Lie down and relax each muscle in turn. Squeeze your feet for 5 seconds, let go. Move up: calves, thighs, belly, hands, shoulders, face. Breathe out slowly.

Evidence: relaxation training is one part of CBT-I, the talk therapy that doctors often recommend first for long-term insomnia (Cleveland Clinic). We do not have a study of this exact 5-minute version.

Minutes 10–11
Set the room

Cool, dark, quiet. Turn off bright lights. Cover or turn away the clock. Cooler air helps your body's natural cooling.

Minute 12
Lights out

Same time every night. Your body likes a pattern. Keep your wake-up time the same too, including weekends.

Bonus: the warm shower trick (1–2 hours before bed)

A 2019 review of 13 studies found that a warm bath or shower (about 104 to 108°F, or 40 to 42.5°C) taken 1 to 2 hours before bed helped people fall asleep about 10 minutes faster on average. The authors said more research is needed on the best timing. Skip it if hot water bothers you or you have heart or blood-pressure issues.

CHAPTER 4

Awake at 3AM? Do this.

This is the 3AM card. Read it now, so you do not have to think at 3AM.

#	Step
1	**Do not check the clock.** The number only makes it worse. Turn the clock away tonight.
2	**Tell yourself:** "This is a normal wake-up. My body knows how to go back to sleep."
3	**Do the muscle-relaxing step** from Minute 5–9 above. Breathe out slowly.
4	**If you feel wide awake after about 15 to 20 minutes** (a rough guide, no clock needed), get up. Go to another room. Keep the lights dim.
5	**Do something quiet and dull** (read a paper book, fold laundry, stretch). No phone, no news, no email.
6	**Go back to bed only when you feel sleepy.** This teaches your brain: bed = sleep, not worry.

This is "stimulus control," a core part of CBT-I. The 15–20 minute number is an approximate guideline, not a rule.

When to see a doctor

Make an appointment if:

- you wake at night most nights for several weeks, or you feel too tired to do your day,
- you snore loudly, gasp, or wake with headaches,
- you have night sweats that soak your sheets, or weight loss you did not try for,
- you feel hopeless, or your mood is low most days.

CBT-I (cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia) works for many people without medicine. Ask your doctor about it.

The bottom line

3AM is a signal, not a sentence. Sometimes it is a normal wake-up your mind blew up. Sometimes it points to something fixable: alcohol, hot nights, breathing, or a full bladder. Test the easy ones first. Take your notes to a doctor for the rest.

YOUR SLEEP DIARY

14-night sleep diary

Fill in each morning. It takes one minute. Bring this page to your doctor.

Night	Bed time	Out of bed	Woke at night (times)	Alcohol? caffeine after 2 p.m.?	Hot / sweaty?	Rested 1–5
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						

What I notice:

SOURCES

Where this comes from

We searched in October 2026. Labels: **A** = official or peer-reviewed source. **B** = news or health-system report of research. **C** = consumer media (rule of thumb only).

1. **Sleep amount.** American Academy of Sleep Medicine and Sleep Research Society: at least 7 hours for adults 18–60. CDC data reported in the news: about 30.5% of adults under 7 hours in 2024. [A/B]
2. **Temperature and melatonin.** PMC2881716 and PubMed 16687320 (thermoregulatory effects of melatonin): sleep onset on the falling slope of core temperature, as melatonin rises. [A]
3. **Sleep cycles and brief wake-ups.** Healthline, "Why do I keep waking up at 3 a.m."; ScienceAlert, "Why you keep waking at 3am": cycles of roughly 90–110 minutes, four to six a night, brief awakenings common. The "cortisol at 3AM" story is only partly accurate. [B/C]
4. **Sleep apnea in women.** Harvard Health, "Sleep apnea symptoms in women: why they may be overlooked"; Mayo Clinic comments (Dr. Stephanie Faubion); Sleep Foundation; a 2026 report on CPAP starters. Insomnia, morning headaches, mood changes more often reported. [A/B]
5. **Menopause night waking.** Harvard Health, "Nighttime awakenings in menopause may be caused by sleep disorders, not hot flashes." [B]
6. **Alcohol and sleep.** Review in *Alcohol* (2014), PMC4427543: faster sleep onset and more deep sleep early; disruption in the second half. [A]
7. **Nocturia.** PMC2824249 and PMC8120610: obstructive sleep apnea and insomnia linked to nocturia in perimenopausal women; estrogen and ADH; pelvic floor. [A]
8. **To-do list study.** Scullin M. & Bliwise D., *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, 2018: 57 young adults; about 16 vs 25 minutes to fall asleep (PubMed 29058942). [A, small]
9. **Warm bath or shower.** Haghayegh S. et al., *Sleep Medicine Reviews*, 2019: 13 studies pooled; 40–42.5°C, 1–2 hours before bed; about 10 minutes faster sleep onset. [A]
10. **CBT-I and stimulus control.** Cleveland Clinic, "Cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia"; University of Washington CBT-I handout: leave bed after roughly 15–20 minutes awake; do not clock-watch. [A/B]

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